ECORAFIKY Collective for Climate Adaptation (ECCA)

Restoring Kenya's Drylands Through Climate-Resilient Agriculture and Market-Led Solutions

1. Background and Rationale

Communities in Kenya's arid and semi-arid lands (ASALs) are increasingly exposed to climate-related pressures, including prolonged drought, declining soil productivity, land degradation and unreliable agricultural production. These challenges affect household food security, livelihoods and the ability of communities to withstand climate shocks. Women smallholder farmers, in particular, often face significant barriers to productive resources, reliable markets and climate-resilient farming opportunities.

Addressing these challenges requires approaches that go beyond short-term agricultural support. There is a need for locally grounded adaptation models that restore degraded land, strengthen resilient food production and create sustainable economic opportunities for the communities that depend on these landscapes.

2. About ECORAFIKY

ECORAFIKY Collective for Climate Adaptation (ECCA) is a community-centred initiative working at the intersection of **dryland restoration, climate-resilient agriculture, food security and livelihoods**.

Our approach is built around a simple idea: land restoration and climate adaptation can be strengthened when communities have viable economic opportunities linked to the productive use of restored land.

We work with women smallholder farmers to promote drought-resilient crops, particularly sorghum, while connecting agricultural production to markets and local food systems. By linking restoration, production, aggregation and value addition, ECORAFIKY seeks to create an approach in which economic activity contributes to the continuity of climate adaptation efforts.

3. Our Approach

ECORAFIKY's model brings together four interconnected areas:

a. Dryland restoration and improved land productivity

We work towards restoring degraded agricultural land through context-appropriate land preparation and restoration practices, including approaches such as ripping, Zai pits and the use

of biochar. The aim is to improve soil conditions, support vegetation recovery and make land more productive and resilient to climate variability.

b. Climate-resilient agricultural production

We support women smallholder farmers to cultivate drought-resistant crops, particularly sorghum, that are better suited to dryland conditions. This provides opportunities to strengthen local food production while supporting livelihoods in climate-affected communities.

c. Market linkages and value addition

We connect farmers to potential markets through aggregation, processing and value addition. Our model explores demand from both industrial buyers and local food systems, creating opportunities for farmers to earn from their produce and for market activity to support the continuity of restoration and agricultural production.

d. Food security and nutrition

Through NutriPop, our developing sorghum-based food product, we are exploring how locally produced agricultural inputs can be transformed into nutritious food for children and school feeding programmes. This creates a link between dryland agricultural production, local value chains and improved access to food.

4. Progress to Date

ECORAFIKY has undertaken an initial restoration and agricultural production pilot in Laikipia, where the project reports:

- 4 hectares of land regenerated.
- An increase in vegetation cover of approximately 30%.
- 4,200 kg of sorghum harvested.
- 30 women farmers engaged in the initiative.
- Initial development and distribution of NutriPop samples.

We are now extending our work in Kitui County, where 55 smallholder women farmers have been engaged and have begun preparing their land for sorghum production. The next phase involves supporting cultivation, purchasing and aggregating harvested produce, and strengthening the links between local production and our wider value-chain model.

NutriPop has also reached an initial minimum viable product stage and is undergoing further refinement to meet the nutritional requirements we are working towards.

5. Climate Adaptation and Expected Outcomes

ECORAFIKY seeks to demonstrate how locally led land restoration and climate-resilient agricultural production can contribute to adaptation while addressing interconnected livelihood and food-security challenges.

Our expected outcomes include:

- Improved land productivity and recovery of degraded dryland areas.
- Increased adoption of drought-resilient agricultural practices and crops.
- Stronger livelihoods and market participation for women smallholder farmers.
- Improved local food-system linkages and opportunities for value addition.
- Greater availability of locally produced food products for communities and school feeding initiatives.
- An economically connected model that can help sustain restoration and adaptation activities beyond short-term project support.

With grant funding secured to support implementation, our 2026 and 2027 targets include expanding restoration activities, increasing the number of women farmers engaged, strengthening agricultural production and developing market pathways. Our current implementation is progressing towards these targets.

6. Opportunities for Collaboration

As ECORAFIKY continues to develop and expand its model, we are interested in opportunities to strengthen its contribution to climate adaptation and food-systems transformation. Potential areas of collaboration include:

- Technical guidance on dryland restoration and climate-resilient agricultural practices.
- Research, monitoring and evidence generation on the relationship between land restoration, agricultural productivity, livelihoods and food security.
- Partnerships that strengthen locally led adaptation and women's participation in climate-resilient food systems.
- Opportunities to connect local production to sustainable markets and wider food-system initiatives.
- Knowledge exchange and opportunities to share lessons from implementation in Kenya's dryland communities.

7. Our Long-Term Vision

Our long-term vision is to demonstrate that dryland restoration can be connected to productive economic systems that strengthen community resilience, support food security and create lasting livelihood opportunities.

We believe climate adaptation efforts are more likely to endure when communities are not only participants in restoration, but also benefit from the economic and social opportunities that restored landscapes can provide.

ECORAFIKY is working to make dryland restoration productive, locally owned and economically sustainable.